

The Home Cook's Handbook

A simple guide to kitchen basics, food safety and everyday recipes

1. Welcome to Your Kitchen

Cooking at home is cheaper, healthier and more fun than most people expect. This handbook covers the basics every beginner needs: how to set up your kitchen, how to keep food safe, how to use common cooking methods, two easy recipes, and how long food lasts in the fridge and freezer.

Five Tools Every Kitchen Needs

- **A sharp chef's knife** (20 cm blade) for cutting almost everything.
- **A large cutting board.** Use a separate board for raw meat.
- **A heavy non-stick frying pan** (26 cm) for eggs, vegetables and rice.
- **A medium saucepan with a lid** for pasta, rice and soups.
- **A digital food thermometer** to check that meat is cooked safely.

Mise en Place

Mise en place is a French term that means "everything in its place." Before you turn on the heat, wash, chop and measure all your ingredients. This prevents mistakes and stops food from burning while you search for the next ingredient.

Knife Safety

Always cut on a stable board. Place a damp cloth under the board so it does not slip. Curl your fingertips inward (the "claw grip") and keep the knife blade moving away from your hand. A sharp knife is safer than a dull one because it needs less force.

2. Food Safety Basics

Food safety protects you from food poisoning. Four rules matter most: clean, separate, cook and chill.

Clean

Wash your hands with soap and warm water for at least 20 seconds before cooking and after touching raw meat, eggs or fish. Wash cutting boards, knives and counters with hot soapy water after each use.

Separate

Keep raw meat, poultry and seafood away from other foods. In the fridge, store raw meat on the bottom shelf so its juices cannot drip onto ready-to-eat foods.

Cook to the Right Temperature

You cannot tell whether meat is safe by its color. Use a food thermometer and insert it into the thickest part.

Food	Safe internal temperature
Chicken, turkey and other poultry	165°F (74°C)
Ground beef, pork and lamb	160°F (71°C)
Steaks, chops and roasts (beef, pork, lamb)	145°F (63°C), then rest for 3 minutes
Fish and shellfish	145°F (63°C)
Eggs cooked for a dish	160°F (71°C)
Leftovers and casseroles	165°F (74°C)

Chill

Bacteria grow fastest between 40°F and 140°F (4°C to 60°C). This is called the "danger zone." Never leave cooked food out for more than 2 hours. If the room is hotter than 90°F (32°C), the limit is 1 hour. Set your refrigerator to 40°F (4°C) or below and your freezer to 0°F (-18°C).

3. Common Cooking Methods

Choosing the right method makes food taste better and keeps more nutrients.

Boiling and Simmering

Boiling uses large bubbles at 212°F (100°C) and is best for pasta, potatoes and eggs.

Simmering uses small, gentle bubbles at about 185°F to 205°F (85°C to 96°C) and is best for soups, stews and sauces. Salt the water for pasta: use about 1 tablespoon of salt for every 4 liters of water.

Sautéing and Stir-Frying

Sautéing cooks small pieces of food quickly in a little oil over medium-high heat. Stir-frying is similar but uses very high heat and constant stirring. Cut all ingredients to the same size so they cook evenly, and do not overcrowd the pan. Too much food in the pan makes it steam instead of brown.

Roasting and Baking

Both methods use dry heat in the oven. Roasting is usually done at 200°C to 230°C (400°F to 450°F) for vegetables and meat, which gives a brown, crisp outside. Baking is used for bread, cakes and casseroles, usually at lower temperatures of 160°C to 190°C (320°F to 375°F).

Always preheat the oven for at least 15 minutes.

Steaming

Steaming cooks food with hot vapor and keeps vitamins that would otherwise be lost in boiling water. Broccoli, carrots and fish steam well. Most vegetables need 5 to 8 minutes.

Grilling

Grilling uses direct, high heat. Let the grill heat for 10 minutes before adding food. Oil the food, not the grate, to prevent sticking. Turn the food only once or twice.

4. Recipe: Simple Tomato Pasta

Serves: 4 **Prep time:** 10 minutes **Cook time:** 20 minutes **Difficulty:** Easy

Ingredients

- 400 g spaghetti or penne
- 2 tablespoons olive oil
- 4 cloves garlic, finely sliced
- 1 can (400 g) crushed tomatoes
- 1 teaspoon salt, plus extra for the pasta water
- 1/2 teaspoon black pepper
- 1 teaspoon dried oregano
- A handful of fresh basil leaves
- 50 g grated Parmesan cheese (optional)

Method

- 1 Bring a large pot of salted water to a boil. Cook the pasta for 9 to 11 minutes, or until tender but still slightly firm. Save 1 cup of the pasta water, then drain.
- 2 While the pasta cooks, heat the olive oil in a large pan over medium heat. Add the garlic and cook for 1 minute. Do not let it turn brown, or it will taste bitter.
- 3 Add the crushed tomatoes, salt, pepper and oregano. Simmer for 12 to 15 minutes, stirring now and then.
- 4 Add the drained pasta to the sauce. Pour in a few spoonfuls of the saved pasta water to make the sauce smooth and glossy.
- 5 Tear in the basil leaves, top with Parmesan, and serve right away.

Tips

Adding a pinch of sugar to the sauce reduces the sharp taste of canned tomatoes. Leftover pasta keeps in the fridge for up to 3 days.

5. Recipe: Vegetable Fried Rice

Serves: 3 **Prep time:** 15 minutes **Cook time:** 10 minutes **Difficulty:** Easy

Why Day-Old Rice Works Best

Freshly cooked rice is soft and sticky, so it turns mushy in the pan. Rice that has been chilled in the fridge overnight is drier and the grains stay separate. Cool the cooked rice within 1 hour and refrigerate it in a shallow container.

Ingredients

- 3 cups cooked, cold rice (about 1 cup of uncooked rice)
- 2 eggs, lightly beaten
- 1 cup mixed vegetables (carrot, peas, green beans), chopped small
- 2 spring onions, sliced
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 2 tablespoons soy sauce
- 1 teaspoon sesame oil
- 2 tablespoons vegetable oil

Method

- 1 Heat 1 tablespoon of vegetable oil in a wok or large pan over high heat. Pour in the eggs and scramble for 1 minute. Move them to a plate.
- 2 Add the remaining oil. Fry the garlic for 15 seconds, then add the carrots and green beans. Stir-fry for 3 minutes.
- 3 Add the rice and peas. Press and stir for 3 to 4 minutes until the rice is hot and slightly crisp.
- 4 Add the soy sauce, sesame oil and the cooked eggs. Mix well for 1 minute.
- 5 Top with spring onions and serve hot.

Tip

Add cooked chicken, tofu or shrimp for extra protein. Make sure chicken reaches 165°F (74°C).

6. Storage Guide: How Long Does Food Last?

These times are for food stored at the correct temperatures (refrigerator at 40°F / 4°C or below, freezer at 0°F / -18°C). When in doubt, throw it out.

Food	Refrigerator	Freezer
Raw chicken or turkey	1 to 2 days	9 months (whole), 4 months (pieces)
Raw ground meat	1 to 2 days	3 to 4 months
Raw steaks and chops	3 to 5 days	4 to 12 months
Raw fish	1 to 2 days	2 to 3 months
Cooked meat and poultry	3 to 4 days	2 to 6 months
Cooked rice and pasta	3 to 4 days	1 to 2 months
Eggs in the shell	3 to 5 weeks	Not recommended
Hard-boiled eggs	1 week	Not recommended
Milk	5 to 7 days after opening	3 months
Hard cheese (opened)	3 to 4 weeks	6 months
Fresh vegetables (most types)	3 to 7 days	8 to 12 months (blanched)

Reheating Leftovers

Reheat all leftovers to 165°F (74°C). Stir halfway through when using a microwave so that heat spreads evenly. Reheat rice only once. Do not reheat it a second time.

Thawing Frozen Food Safely

Thaw food in the refrigerator, in a bowl of cold water (change the water every 30 minutes), or in the microwave. Never thaw food on the counter at room temperature.

7. Nutrition Basics

A balanced meal gives your body the energy and nutrients it needs. Aim to include foods from each group below.

The Main Nutrients

- **Carbohydrates** give you energy. Sources: rice, bread, pasta, potatoes, fruit. Provide 4 calories per gram.
- **Protein** builds and repairs muscles. Sources: eggs, chicken, fish, beans, lentils, tofu, dairy. Provide 4 calories per gram.
- **Fat** supports the brain and helps absorb vitamins. Sources: olive oil, nuts, avocado, fish. Provide 9 calories per gram.
- **Fiber** helps digestion. Sources: whole grains, vegetables, fruit, beans. Adults need about 25 to 30 grams a day.
- **Vitamins and minerals** keep your body working well. Eat many colors of fruit and vegetables.

The Plate Method

A simple way to build a balanced plate is to fill half of it with vegetables and fruit, one quarter with whole grains such as brown rice or whole wheat pasta, and one quarter with protein. Add a small amount of healthy fat, such as olive oil.

Water

Most adults should drink about 2 liters (8 cups) of water a day. You may need more in hot weather or when you exercise.

Easy Healthy Swaps

- Choose brown rice instead of white rice for more fiber.
- Bake or grill food instead of deep frying it.
- Use herbs, lemon and spices instead of extra salt.
- Replace sugary drinks with water or unsweetened tea.

This handbook is for general information only and is not medical advice.